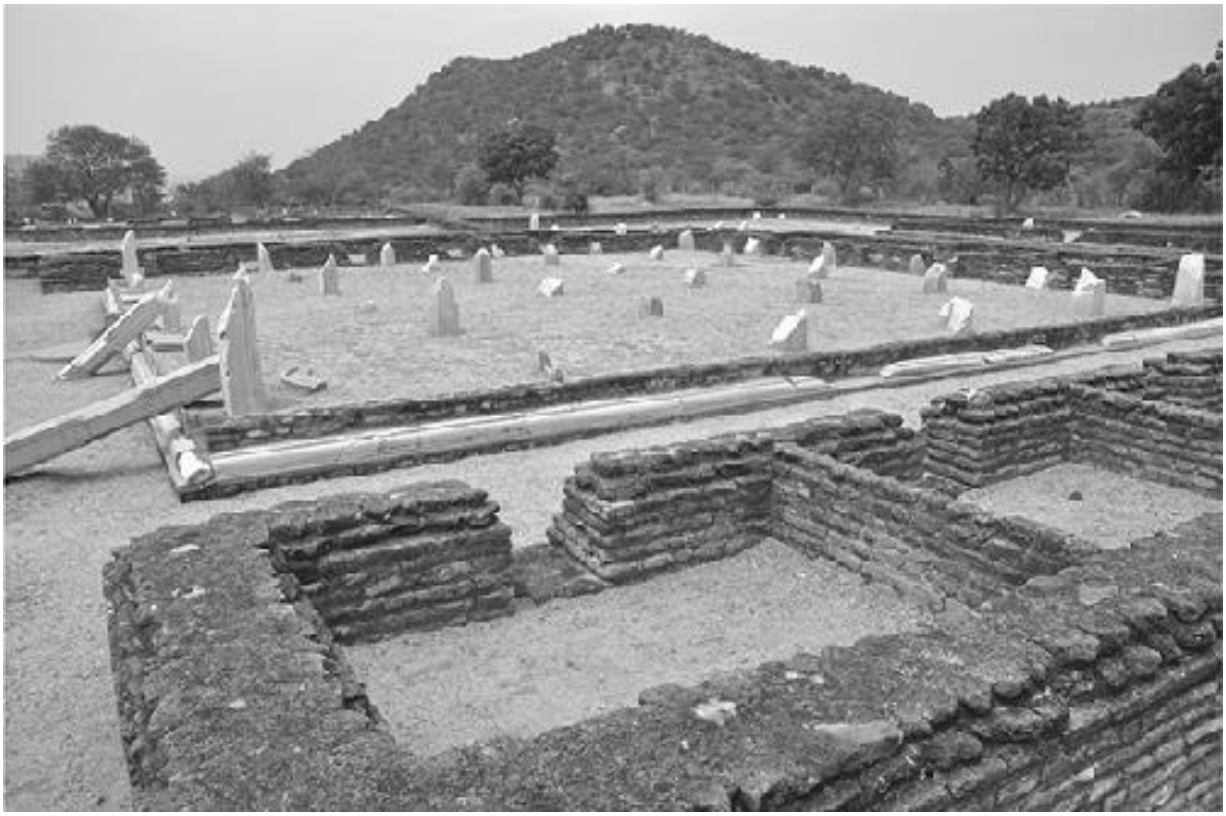


Figure 3. A Buddhist monastic complex

We learn that the Ceylonese, who trade actively with Vijayapuri, have been provided an entire monastery just to host their visiting monks. As a group, they patronize the more orthodox Hinayana sects that oppose image worship of the Buddha—a trend being popularized by the rival Mahayana sects and which would eventually prevail in India.[*]

A fifteen-minute stroll east of the citadel brings us to the Great Stupa, which predates the Ikshvakus but which, during the early Ikshvaku rule, was renovated and grew to about 70–80 feet high and over 100 feet wide. It has finely carved relief sculpture and hosts a bone relic of the Buddha, hidden so creatively that it'll survive the plunder of treasure seekers until discovered by Longhurst around 1928 (it's now at Mulagandhakuti Vihara at Sarnath, UP).[*] Inscriptions at this stupa and at other Buddhist sites record the names of their major patrons, and we find it curious that the most prominent among them are wealthy women, both royal and not. Pilgrims